

Knowing What the Body Is Capable of: Embodied Understanding and Identity Construction in Women's Outdoor Adventure

ABSTRACT

Women's outdoor adventure has often been examined in relation to motivation, risk, wellbeing, and empowerment, yet less is known about how women come to reinterpret themselves through the embodied work of moving, learning, and negotiating limits in outdoor environments. Based on thematic analysis of 31 in-depth interviews with Chinese women involved in soft adventure activities, this study examines how outdoor participation shapes embodied self-understanding. Bringing theories of embodiment into conversation with identity work, we conceptualise outdoor adventure as a site where the body becomes both the medium and the object of self-revision. The analysis shows that this identity work unfolded through three connected processes: sensory immersion redirected attention from social performance to bodily presence; encounters with fatigue, danger, and uncertainty turned bodily limits into matters of interpretation and judgement; and repeated skill acquisition converted temporary achievement into more durable claims about capability, femininity, and agency. These changes, however, were neither automatic nor universal. For some participants, adventure remained a recreational escape with limited carry-over into everyday life. What mattered was whether women could claim authority over their own bodily experience: what to endure, what to refuse, and what to carry back. The study contributes to tourism and leisure scholarship by showing that empowerment in women's soft adventure emerges through embodied identity work rather than exposure to risk alone.

Keywords: Embodied Identity Work; Women; Soft Adventure Tourism; Empowerment; Limit Negotiation; China